

THE GENESIS OF AN ARCHETYPE

SELF-IMPROVEMENT

CIVIC DUTY

INDUSTRY

SCIENTIFIC INQUIRY

How Benjamin Franklin Invented Himself
and Defined the American Character.

VIRTUE

SCIENTIFIC INQUIRY
and knows very correlative

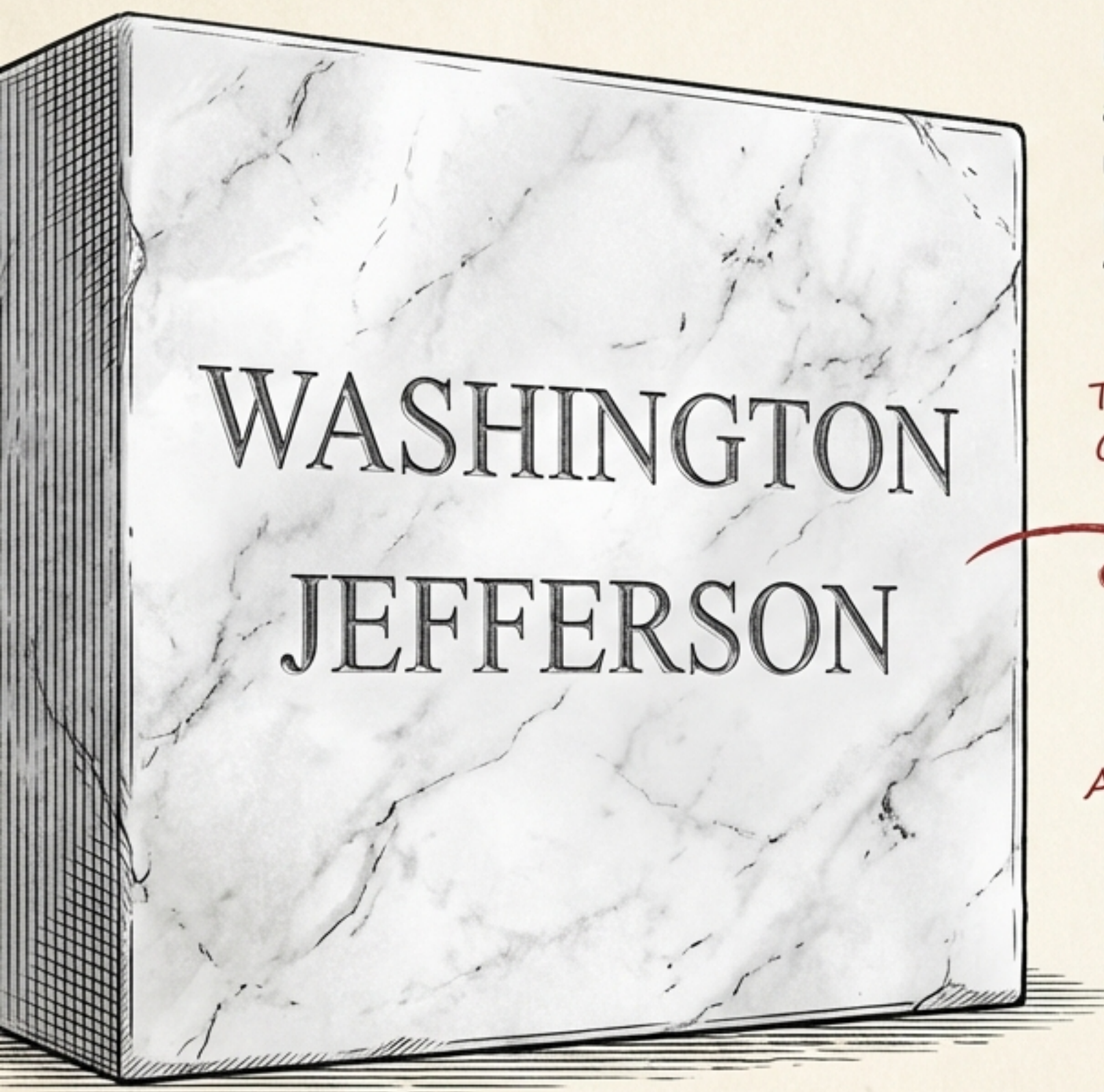
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THE FOUNDING YUPPIE

KEY INSIGHT: Franklin is the prototype of the ambitious urban entrepreneur. He represents the “middling people”—a meritocratic class defined by social mobility, not aristocracy.

Unlike the “marble” statues of Washington and Jefferson—who feel intimidating and untouchable—Franklin is made of flesh and blood. He is the only Founding Father who “winks” at us.



WASHINGTON
JEFFERSON

The Human Connection

A knowing wink



“Our founding Yuppie.” — *David Brooks*

Peeling Back the Layers

Layer 2 (The Author): The 65-year-old wry observer in an English country house, writing this scene to remind his aristocratic, illegitimate son of his humble roots.

*Layer 1 (The Event):
The bedraggled runaway
straggling off the boat,
cheeky yet pretending
humility.*



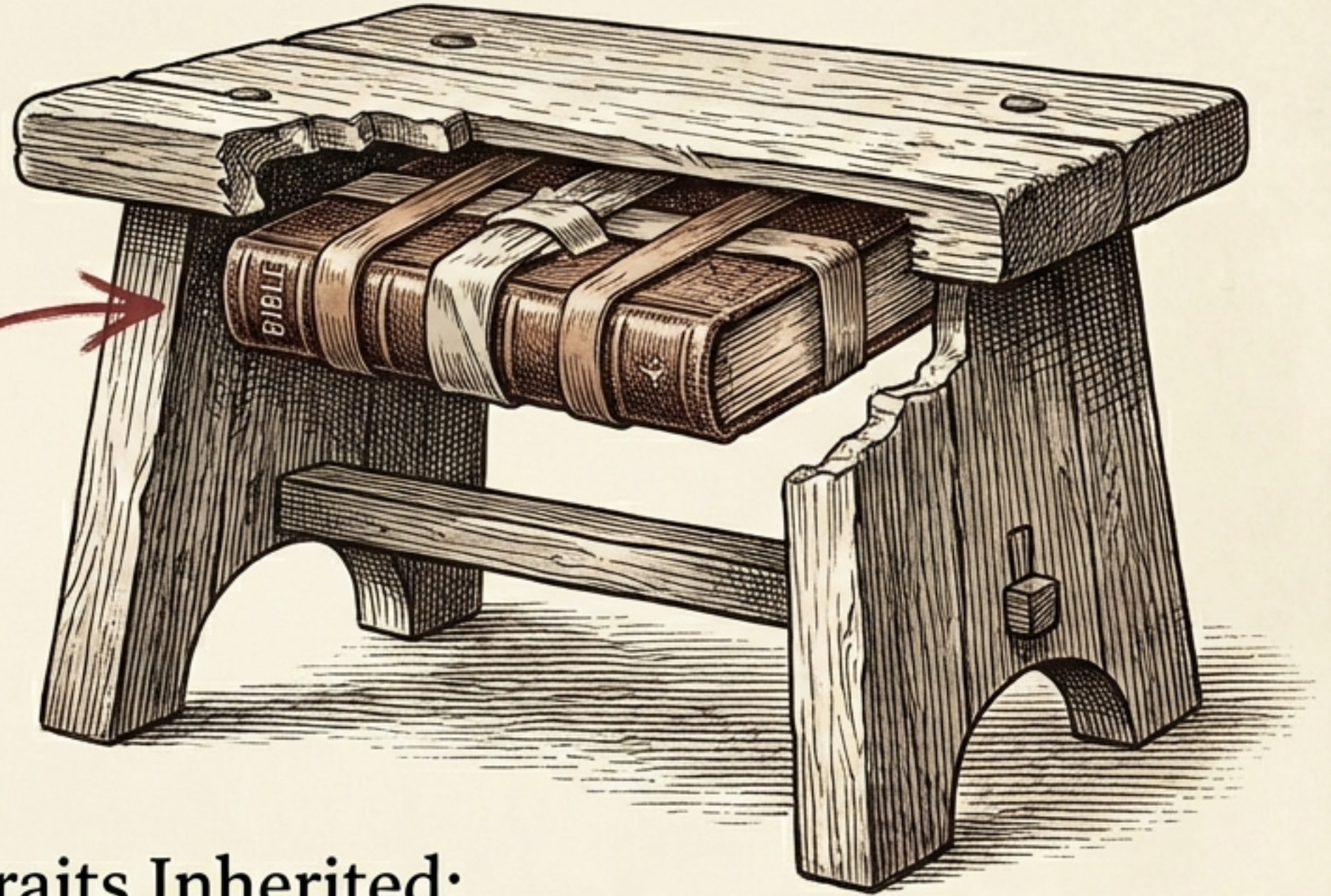
*Layer 3 (The Edit):
Deborah Read stands
here. She saw me and
thought I made, as
I certainly did, a
most awkward
ridiculous
appearance.*

The "B. Franklin" we know is a carefully crafted multi-layered persona.

THE DNA OF DISSENT: THE FRANKLINS

The name “Franklin” comes from “Frankeleyn”—a medieval class of land-owning freemen, neither aristocrats nor peasants.

The Hidden Bible: Ancestor Thomas Franklin (b. 1540) hid a banned English Bible here to hide it from the Catholic “apparitor”. He would flip the stool to read, and flip it back to hide.



Key Traits Inherited:

1. Ingenuity and craftsmanship



2. A “Protestant Ethic” tied to resistance



3. Deep convictions worn lightly.

THE DNA OF REBELLION: THE FOLGERS

Franklin was a “product of lineage rather than of land.” His mother, Abiah Folger, came from a line of restless reformist Protestants.

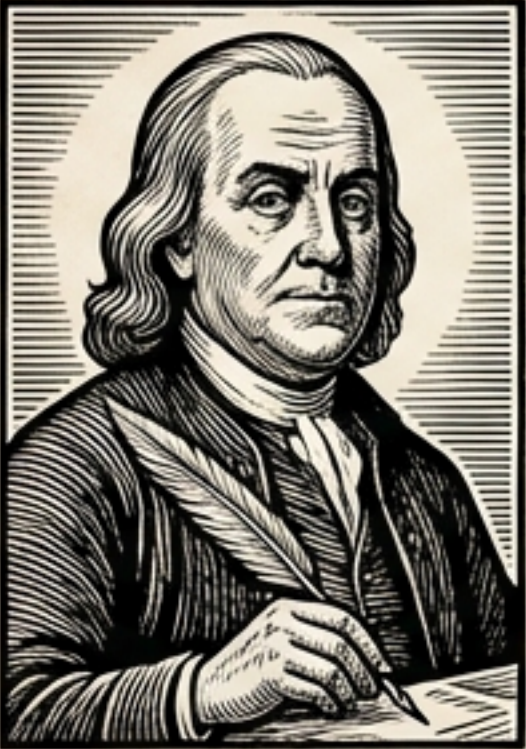
*A “godly rebel”
against the elite*

*Satire as a
weapon!*

*The true source
of Ben’s fire*

*The true source
of Ben’s fire*

Character Card



Peter Folger (Grandfather)

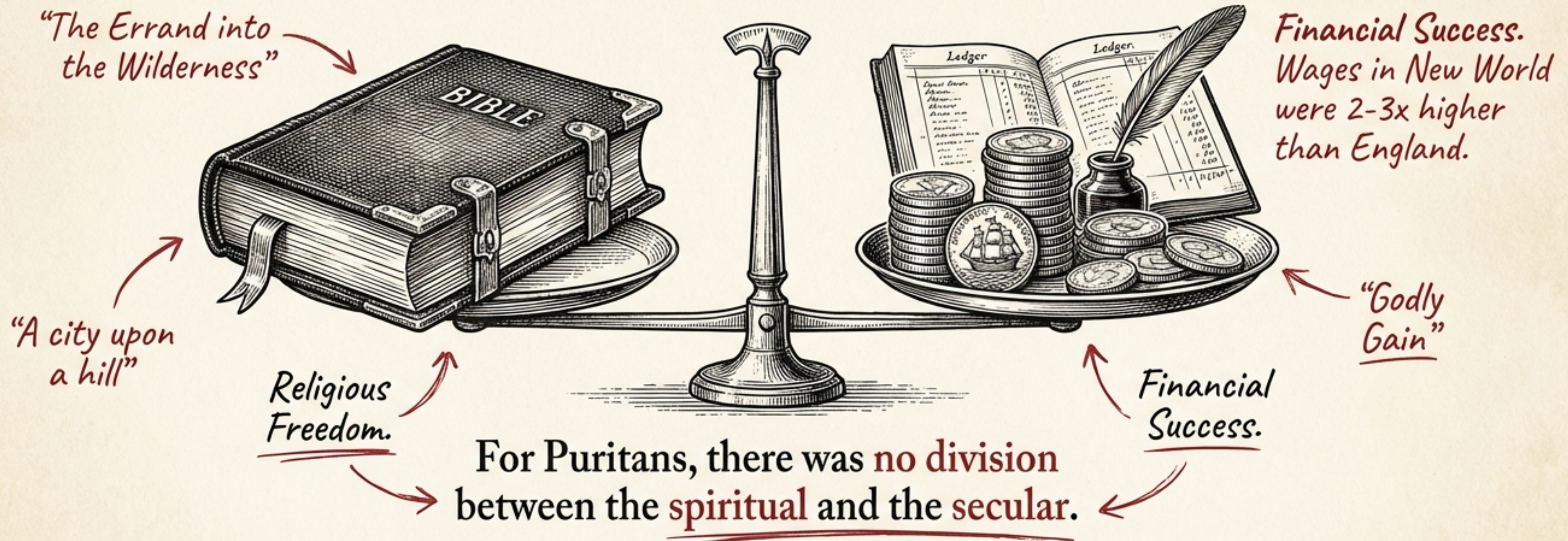
Role: Schoolmaster & Surveyor, Nantucket

Action: Jailed for defying the local magistrate in defense of the middle class.

Legacy: Wrote seditious poetry criticizing Puritan intolerance.

The Marriage: Handy, Pragmatic Franklins + Rebellious, Zealous Folgers = Benjamin Franklin.

THE PURITAN PARADOX



"Diligence in thy calling." (Proverbs 22:29). Industriousness is next to godliness.



The Father: Josiah Franklin

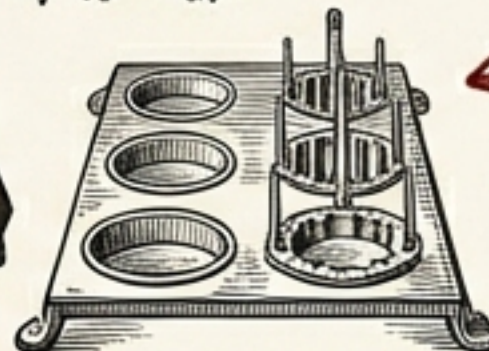
*Tallow Chandlery:
A life of grime*



Solid as rock



*The light
of the
family.*



Sidebar Profile

Profession: Tallow Chandler *Essential*
(Candle & Soap Maker). A *but*
trade of utility, not glamour. *unrefined*

Status: Tithing-man. *Community*
Watched for "nightwalkers *Enforcer*
and tipplers".

Role: The Arbiter of
Solid Judgment.

*The Patriarch's
Law.*

The Conflict

Josiah intended Benjamin (his 10th *A planned*
son) as his "Tithe to the Church"—a life *destiny*
of clergy service. He *damp* *Clash of Visions:*
Ben's poetic aspirations as *Utility vs. Art*
impractical paths to poverty. *The Fear of*
Destitution

“The Crucible of the Candle Shop”

The shop represented the old hierarchy; the water represented innovation and escape.



The Shop

Age 10.
The odiferous trade of
rendering animal fat.
Mindless drudgery.

A life of grime.

*Mindless,
repetitive toil.*

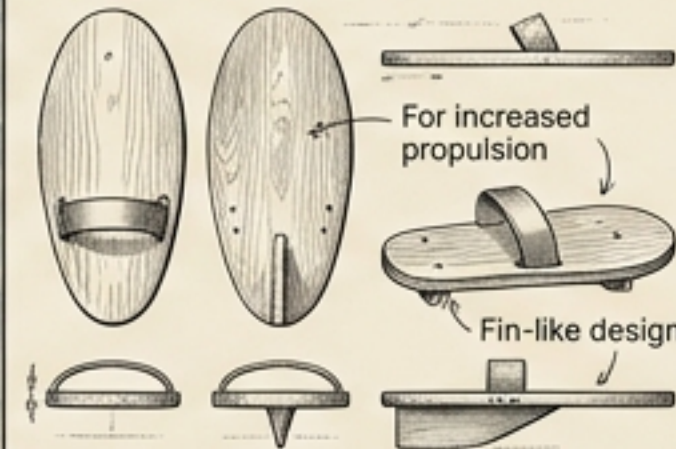
The Escape

*Water: A space
for discovery.*

*Innovations born
of boredom*

*Early
Engineering*

The Inventor



Escape from the known

*Harnessing
Wind Power*

The Wharf Builder



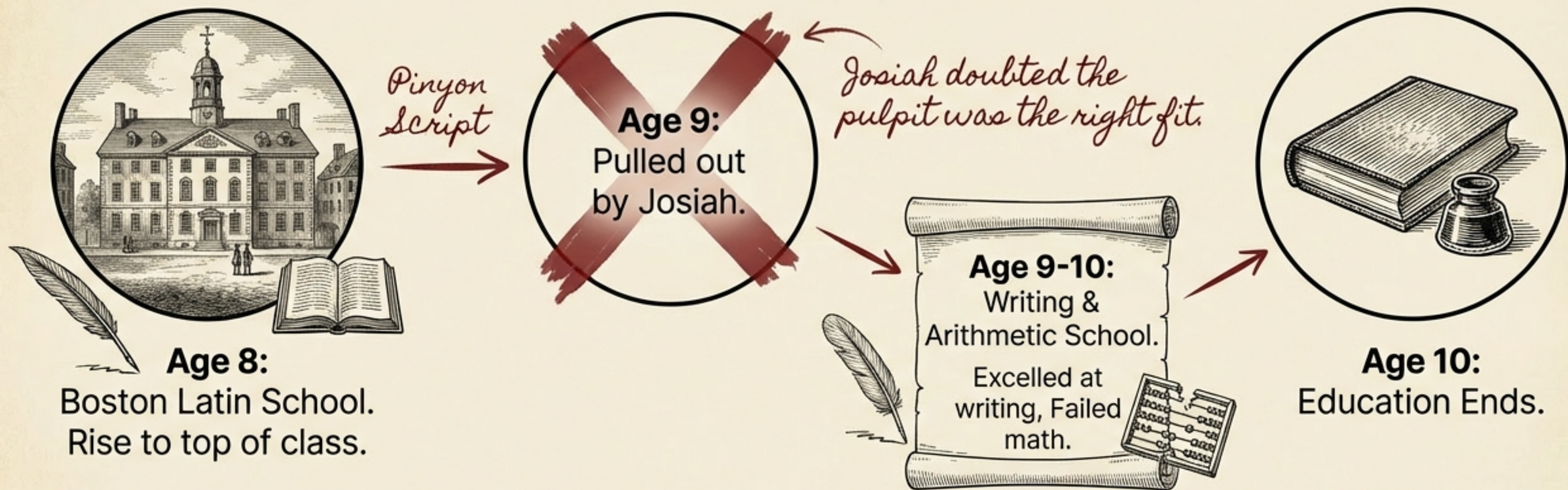
*Experimental
Design*

*Escape from
the known*

The Kite



The Dropout



Total Formal Schooling: 2 Years.

He would be a "Leather Apron Man," not a Harvard man.

The greatest scientist of his era was a dropout.

Utility vs. Status

The Tool Kit: Mentors in Print

“All the little money that came into my hands
was ever laid out in books.”



← *Taught narration
mixed with dialogue.*

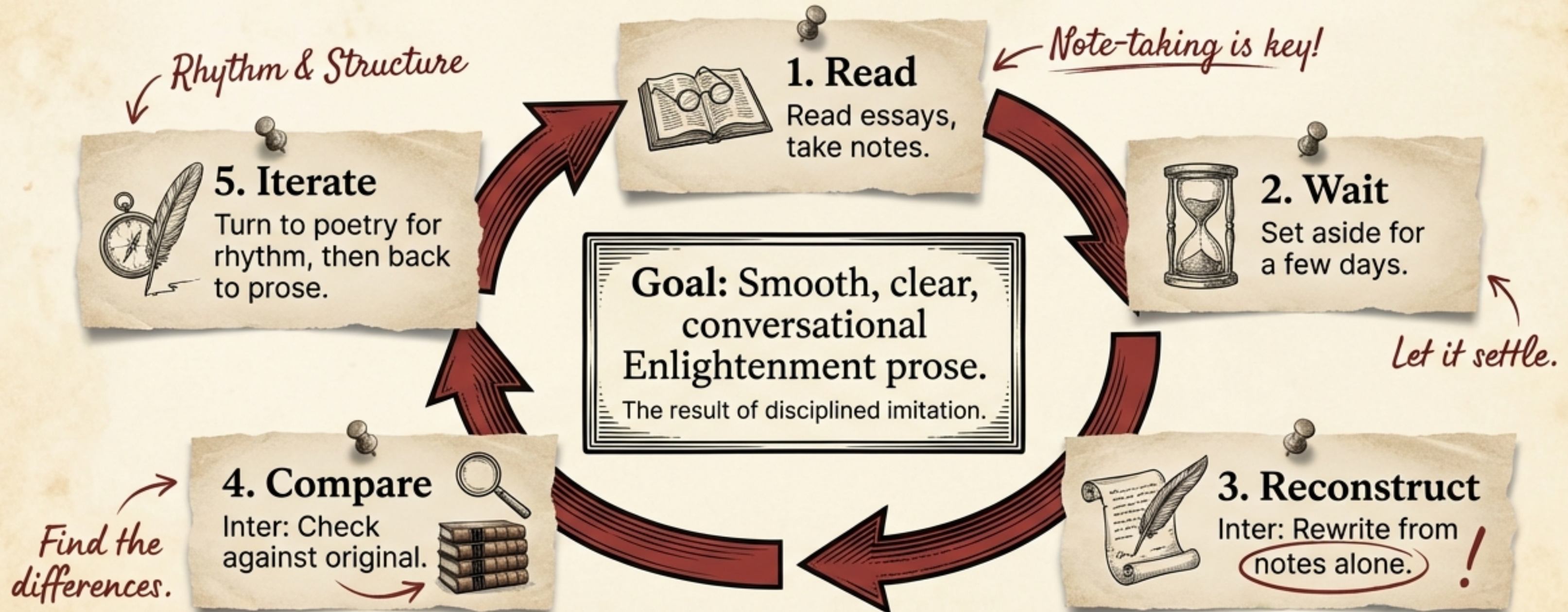
← *History is shaped
by character.*

← *Civic improvement
seeds.*

← *Doing good for the
community.*

How to Write Like Franklin

The Spectator Method



The Art of Persuasion

Disputatious



Abrupt contradiction.
Creating enemies.

Socratic Method



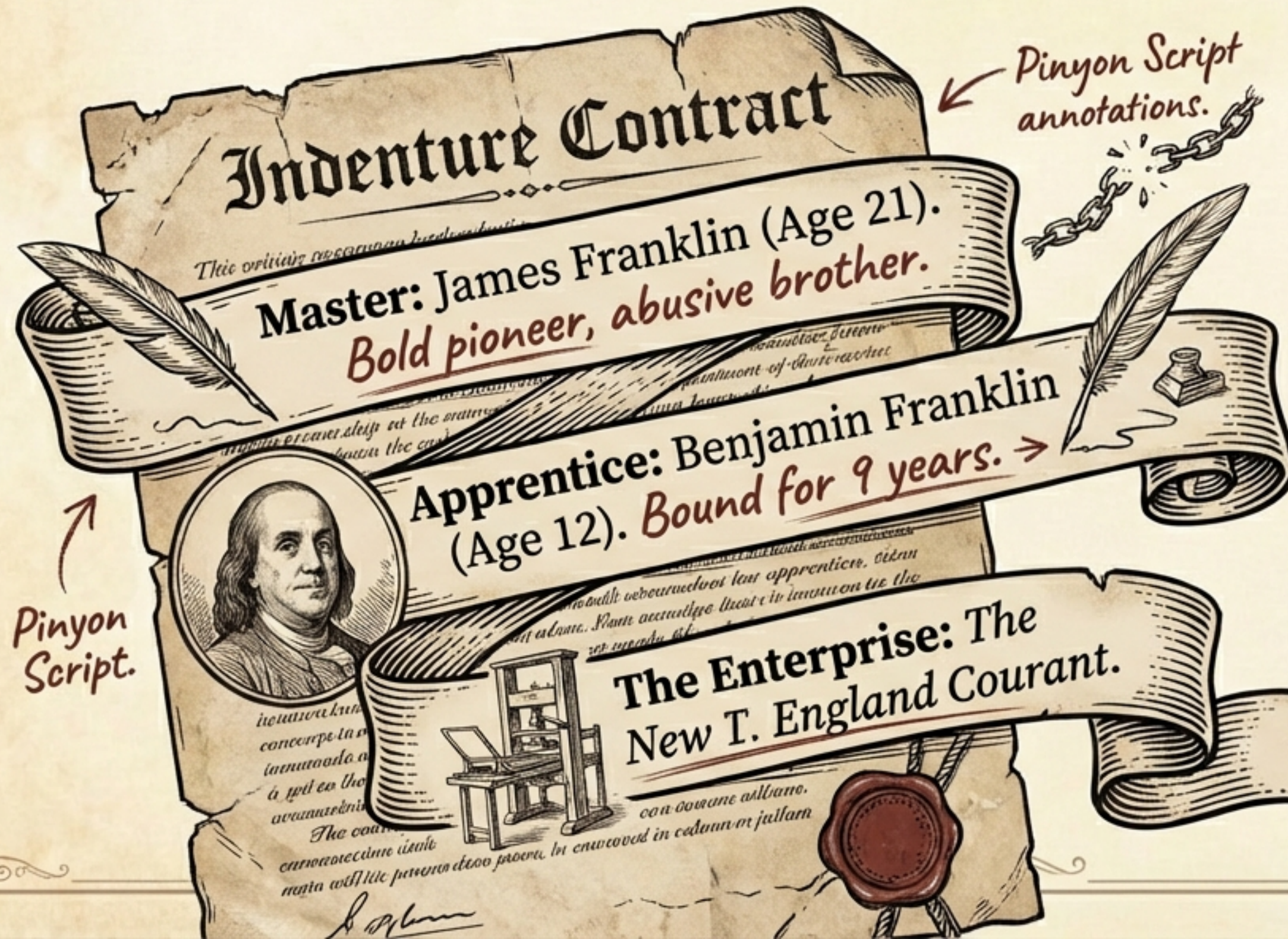
The safe way.

1. Drop the abrupt contradiction.
2. Adopt the role of the "humble inquirer."
3. Ask innocent questions that lead the opponent into a trap.

"I found this method the safest for myself and very embarrassing to those against whom I used it."

B. Franklin

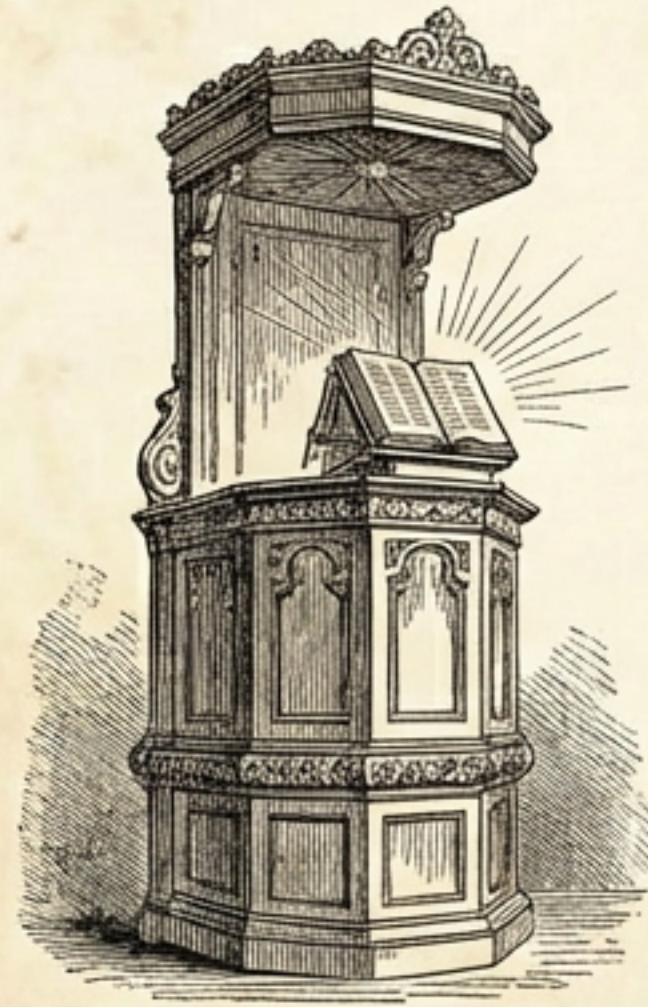
The Apprentice and the Tyrant



- First independent newspaper in the colonies.
- Modeled on London's literary culture.
- NOT "Published by Authority."

Context: The Smallpox Feud (1721)

The Religious Establishment (Cotton Mather)



PRO-INOCULATION

(Learned from
African slave)

Unexpected Source!

The Liberals & The Press (James Franklin)



ANTI-INOCULATION

(To spite the
arrogant clergy)

Political Motive!

The *Courant* attacked the Establishment, creating
a tradition of an irreverent press, even if they
were scientifically wrong.

The First Invention: Silence Dogood



- **The Persona:** A middle-aged widow from the country.
- **Traits:** Enemy to arbitrary government. Jealous of liberties. Critical of hypocrisy.
- **The Feat:** A 16-year-old boy convincingly writing as a woman.
- **The Method:** Slipping anonymous letters under the print shop door at night.

Like this one! (Young Ben's trick)

Satirizing the Elite



Dogood's Dream: Students exit having learned only how to "enter a room genteelly."
Class warfare via satire.

↑
Like this one!
(Young Ben's trick)

The Apprentice Takes Command



The Loophole: James couldn't enforce the secret contract without admitting to the public fraud.

Teenager Ben ran the most controversial paper in America.

The Runaway

*Escape from
James*

*A New
Beginning*



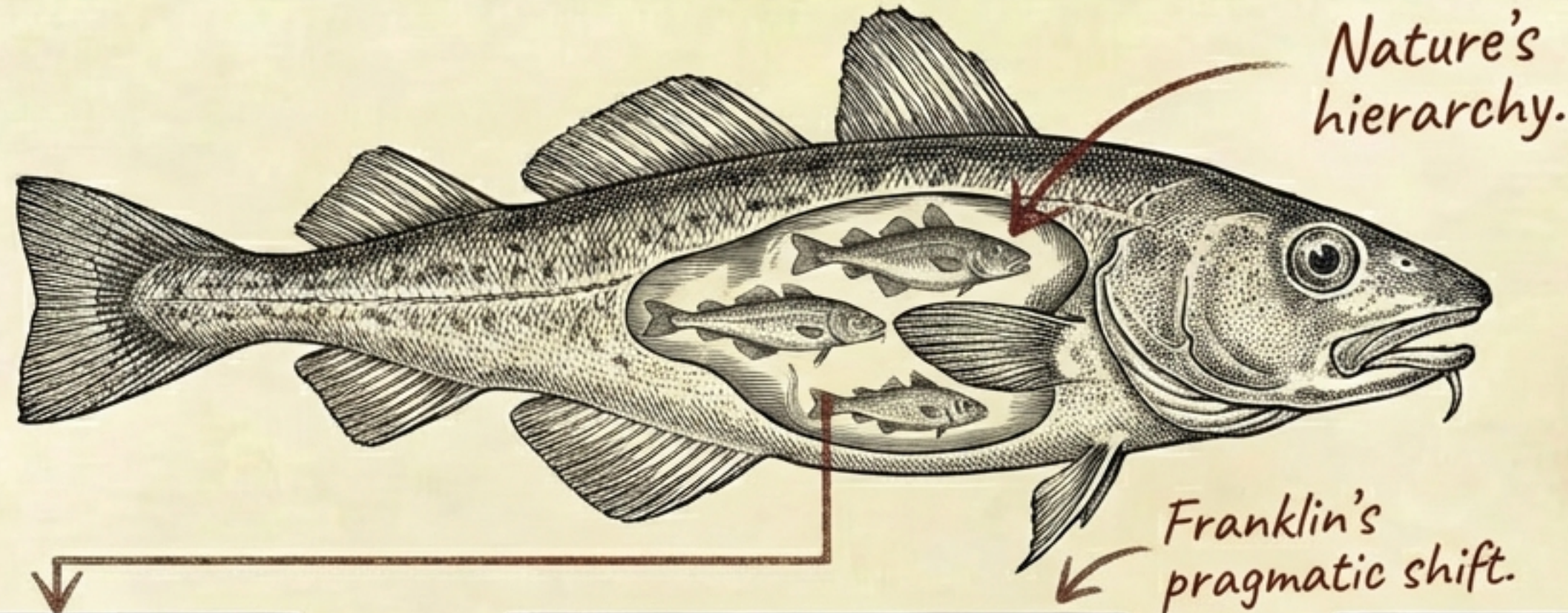
September 25, 1723.
Fugitive Apprentice.

*A Daring
Escape*

The Shift:
He didn't
flee to the
wilderness. He
fled to the City.

"I fancy his harsh treatment... might be a means of impressing me with that aversion to arbitrary power."

The Codfish Rationalization



Observation: Big fish eat little fish.

Logic: If you eat one another, I don't see why we may not eat you.

Action:
Dining Heartily.

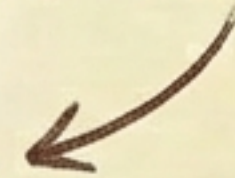
"So convenient a thing it is to be a reasonable creature, since it enables one to find or make a reason for everything one has a mind to do." *A flexible conscience!*

B. Franklin, Printer

*A humble
start*



*Destiny
foreshadowed*



Arrival: Sunday Morning, Philadelphia.

“He had separated from his past—aristocracy, family trade, dogma—to become the first American Archetype: The Self-Made Man.”

*The First
American*